

A/An vs One

CEFR A2

Lesson Pack · summary, worksheet & answer key

Quick answer

Both come before a singular noun, but the focus is different:

- 1 a/an — naming something; number not important (Can I have a coffee?).
- 2 one — the number matters, in contrast to more (I ordered one coffee, not two).

Use 'one' to stress quantity or in fixed uses: one day, one of them, the blue one. Jobs and general 'first mention' take a/an.

At a glance

Word	Use	Example
a/an	name a singular noun; number unimportant	I need a ticket.
one	the number matters (not two+)	I only need one ticket.
one	fixed uses / pronoun	one day; the red one

Learning objectives

- Can use a/an to name a singular noun where number is unimportant (CEFR A2).
- Can use 'one' when the exact number matters or as a pronoun.
- Can avoid 'one' before jobs and general first mentions.

Practice worksheet

Circle the correct option. A/An vs One · CEFR A2

Name: _____

Date: _____

1. She's ____ engineer at a tech company.

- | | |
|-------|------------|
| A. an | B. one |
| C. a | D. the one |

2. I have ____ brother and two sisters. (stressing the number)

- | | |
|--------|------------|
| A. one | B. a |
| C. an | D. the one |

3. Can I have ____ coffee, please? (just ordering)

- | | |
|------------|-------------|
| A. a | B. one only |
| C. the one | D. an |

4. ____ day I'll visit Japan.

- | | |
|--------|------------|
| A. One | B. A |
| C. An | D. The one |

5. There are two jackets. I'll take the black ____ .

- | | |
|--------|-------|
| A. one | B. a |
| C. an | D. it |

6. He's ____ of my best friends.

- | | |
|--------|----------|
| A. one | B. a |
| C. an | D. the a |

7. Only ____ student passed the exam — everyone else failed.

- | | |
|--------|----------|
| A. one | B. a |
| C. an | D. the a |

8. I saw ____ amazing film last night.

- | | |
|-------|------------|
| A. an | B. one |
| C. a | D. the one |

9. Correct this: 'My mother is one doctor.'

- | | |
|----------------------------|---------------------------------|
| A. My mother is a doctor. | B. My mother is one doctor. |
| C. My mother is an doctor. | D. My mother is the one doctor. |

10. When do you use 'one' instead of 'a/an'?

- | | |
|--|--------------------------------|
| A. When the exact number matters, or as a pronoun. | B. Before every singular noun. |
| C. Before jobs and roles. | D. Only in questions. |

Answer key

Correct answers with explanations · for the teacher

1. **A. an** — Jobs take a/an; 'engineer' has a vowel sound: 'an engineer'.
2. **A. one** — Contrast with 'two sisters' makes the number matter: 'one brother'.
3. **A. a** — Naming a drink: 'a coffee'.
4. **A. One** — Fixed phrase: 'One day I'll... '.
5. **A. one** — 'One' replaces the noun: 'the black one'.
6. **A. one** — 'One of my best friends' — the fixed pattern.
7. **A. one** — Stressing the number: 'only one student'.
8. **A. an** — Naming it; 'amazing' has a vowel sound: 'an amazing film'.
9. **A. My mother is a doctor.** — Jobs take a/an: 'a doctor'.
10. **A. When the exact number matters, or as a pronoun.** — 'One' stresses number, or replaces a noun.